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Timeline & Challenge Overview, What You're Building Towards

1 message

AI Grand Prix <contact_aigp@theaigraprix.com>

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Hi Matthew Hutchinson,

Welcome to this week's update! With the competition season approaching fast, we want to give you a clear picture of what's coming and what exactly you'll be working on.

Key Competition Milestones: The Path to the AI Grand Prix

1st Virtual Qualifier | Opens in May 2026

2nd Virtual Qualifier | Opens in June 2026

Physical Qualifier & AI Grand Prix | September and November 2026

The virtual qualifiers are your gateway to the next stages – **make sure your software is ready when the window opens**. We'll share exact dates and submission details in the coming weeks.

The Challenge: What You Need to Build

Your task is to develop an autonomous system that can navigate a drone through a sequence of gates inside a virtual environment, as fast as possible.

This means your software needs to handle:

- Gate recognition: Detect and locate gates in the virtual environment using available sensor data and a visual data feed. Gates will mostly be standardized.
- Drone control: Command the drone's flight dynamics (speed, orientation, thrust) with precision. There will be a balance to be found between speed and accuracy.
- Path planning & navigation: Plot and follow an efficient route through all gates in the correct order, under realistic physical limitations of the drone's capabilities.

The goal is simple: complete all gates in the shortest time possible. The fastest time wins.

There are no shortcuts: no manual control, no hardware advantages. It's all about the quality of your code. We have an open-minded approach to the type of the intelligence you want to apply to the challenge, with the final time being the ultimate decider. Out-of-the-box thinking is explicitly encouraged. We will continue to release information about the requirements / interfaces as the qualifier gets closer.

What's Next

In the upcoming week, we'll cover:

- More details about the 1st Virtual Qualifier
- Initial instructions regarding delivery of code
- Start thinking about your approach, whether it's classical control, reinforcement learning, computer vision, or a hybrid stack. Also, now is the time to search for team members if you don't want to tackle the challenge alone (a team can consist of up to 8 team members). The clock is ticking.

Good luck and happy coding,

The AI Grand Prix Team

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